



Gender Bias in Admissions Process

Introduction

The University of Toronto is an equal opportunity university when it comes to its admission process. Students are admitted to the school based on merit alone, but any process may have shortcomings. Recently there has been some concern about potential biases in the process and a study has been commissioned to determine if the process used has biases. One of the most concerning biases is gender bias.

Problem Statement

The school believes male applicants may be favoured compared to female applicants, and this is causing the unbalanced number of male students and female students.

What the Data Tells Us

The school provided data for 12,763 people who applied for different majors. The data included their gender, major, and acceptance status. A subset of people who applied for Majors A, B, C, D, E, and F was obtained and analysed to check for gender bias. This subset was made up of 4,839 applicants, composed of 1,835 female applicants and 3,004 male applicants with 2068 of all applicants being accepted, which is a 42.74% acceptance rate.

At first glance, it does seem like there is a gender bias in the admissions process and male applicants are favoured. This is supported by the fact the female admission rate is 30% with only 557 females accepted while the male admission rate is 50% with 1511 males accepted.

Looking deeper into the data tells a different story. When you consider the differences in majors applied for, we get a clearer picture. Females applying to the university apply to study majors C, D, E, or F, with 93% of them doing so. These majors have a low combined acceptance rate of 26% overall, 25.5% for males, and 26.5% for females. Contrasting this with acceptance rates for majors A and B, which have a combined acceptance rate of 70%, 69% for males and 80% for females, but only 7% of the females who applied to the university applied for these majors.

Conclusion

When the major applied for is considered, females have a higher acceptance rate in both low acceptance and high acceptance majors, but they predominantly choose to apply for low acceptance majors. This indicates no gender bias in admissions, but more so females' preferences on which major to study. The university can try to increase female applications in majors A and B to equalise the student population but not much else can be done.